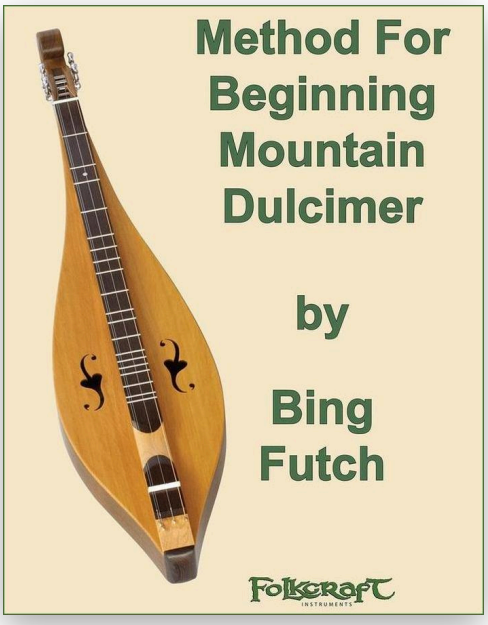
FINGERS OF STEEL® PUBLICATIONS

Method For Beginning Mountain Dulcimer

by Bing Futch

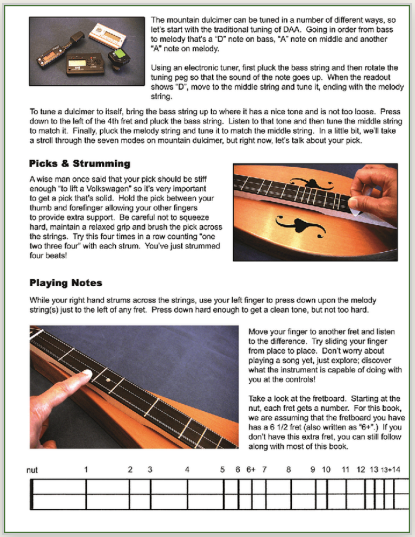


Method For Beginning Mountain Dulcimer by Bing Futch is one of the most comprehensive books available for learning the mountain dulcimer. You start playing songs right away, and the book goes much further than the basics, covering technique, repertoire, theory and history.

Besides DAD, the songs and exercises use older tunings such as DAA and DGD, which players used more widely 70 to 120 years ago. Because those alternate tunings can intimidate newcomers, this works best as your second dulcimer book. Pair it with a "First Lessons" book and you'll be set.

133 pages | Free demo audio

INSIDE THE BOOK


The mountain dulcimer can be tuned in a number of different ways, so let's start with the traditional tuning of DAA. Going in order from bass to melody that's a "D" note on bass, "A" note on middle and another "A" note on melody.

Using an electronic tuner, first pluck the bass string and then rotate the tuning peg so that the sound of the note goes up. When the readout shows "D", move to the middle string and tune it, ending with the melody string.

To tune a dulcimer to itself, bring the bass string up to where it has a nice tone and is not too loose. Press down to the left of the 4th fret and pluck the bass string. Listen to that tone and then tune the middle string to match it. Finally, pluck the melody string and tune it to match the middle string. In a little bit, we'll take a stroll through the seven modes on mountain dulcimer, but right now, let's talk about your pick.

Picks & Strumming

A wise man once said that your pick should be stiff enough "to lift a Volkswagen" so it's very important to get a pick that's solid. Hold the pick between your thumb and forefinger allowing your other fingers to provide extra support. Be careful not to squeeze hard, maintain a relaxed grip and brush the pick across the strings. Try this four times in a row counting "one two three four" with each strum. You've just strummed four beats!

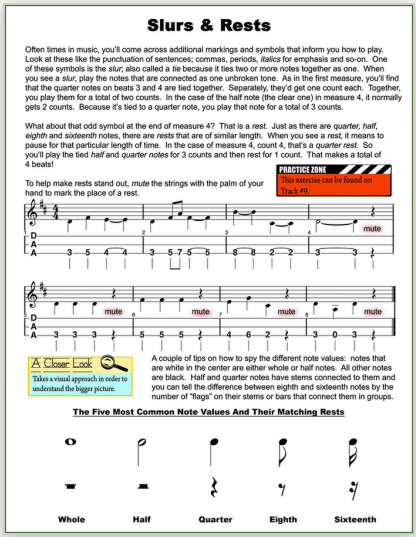
Playing Notes

While your right hand strums across the strings, use your left finger to press down upon the melody string(s) just to the left of any fret. Press down hard enough to get a clean tone, but not too hard.

Move your finger to another fret and listen to the difference. Try sliding your finger from place to place. Don't worry about playing a song yet, just explore; discover what the instrument is capable of doing with you at the controls!

Take a look at the fretboard. Starting at the nut, each fret gets a number. For this book, we are assuming that the fretboard you have has a 6 1/2 fret (also written as "6+".) If you don't have this extra fret, you can still follow along with most of this book.

nut 1 2 3 4 5 6 6+ 7 8 9 10 11 12 13 13+14


Slurs & Rests

Often times in music, you'll come across additional markings and symbols that inform you how to play. Look at these like the punctuation of sentences; commas, periods, *italics* for emphasis and so-on. One of these symbols is the *slur*; also called a *tie* because it ties two or more notes together as one. When you see a *slur*, play the notes that are connected as one unbroken tone. As in the first measure, you'll find that the quarter notes on beats 3 and 4 are tied together. Separately, they'd get one count each. Together, you play them for a total of two counts. In the case of the half note (the clear one) in measure 4, it normally gets 2 counts. Because it's tied to a quarter note, you play that note for a total of 3 counts.

What about that odd symbol at the end of measure 4? That is a *rest*. Just as there are *quarter, half, eighth* and *sixteenth* notes, there are *rests* that are of similar length. When you see a *rest*, it means to pause for that particular length of time. In the case of measure 4, count 4, that's a *quarter rest*. So you'll play the tied *half* and *quarter notes* for 3 counts and then rest for 1 count. That makes a total of 4 beats!

PRACTICE ZONE This exercise can be found on Track #9.

To help make rests stand out, *mute* the strings with the palm of your hand to mark the place of a rest.
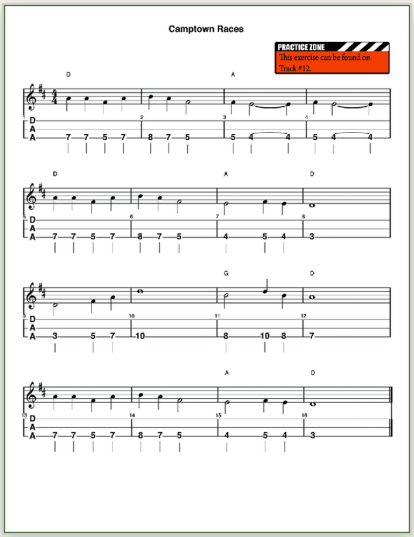
mute

A Closer Look Takes a visual approach in order to understand the bigger picture.

A couple of tips on how to spy the different note values: notes that are white in the center are either whole or half notes. All other notes are black. Half and quarter notes have stems connected to them and you can tell the difference between eighth and sixteenth notes by the number of "flags" on their stems or bars that connect them in groups.

The Five Most Common Note Values And Their Matching Rests

Whole Half Quarter Eighth Sixteenth


Camptown Races

PRACTICE ZONE This exercise can be found on Track #12.

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